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MEDIA & EVENTS

Ray Varner Ford — September 2026 Digital Advertising Summary

Reporting period: September 1 – September 30, 2026

After the Changeover Rush

September is the month after the model-year changeover peak. August pulled a lot of buyers forward with outgoing-year pricing and the first next-year arrivals, and September is typically when that activity settles while new model-year inventory fills in. The numbers this month reflect that cooling. Advertising reach and search performance held up well, but shopping activity on the site eased back from August's high.

September at a Glance

- Site-wide visitors: **11,067** (essentially flat, down 1.4% from 11,229)
- Visitors from the ads: **7,259** (flat, down 0.2%)
- Search click-through rate: **12.66%** (up from 11.07%) on **2,494** clicks (up 4.3%)
- Search market share: **19.63%** (up slightly from 19.48%, a sixth straight monthly gain)
- Direct calls from ads: **80** (down from 86)
- Vehicle detail page views: **6,901** site-wide (down 17.2%)
- Lead form submissions: **45** site-wide (down from 74)

Search Got Sharper

Search did more with less. Search impressions eased 8.8% to 19,696, but clicks rose 4.3% to 2,494, lifting click-through rate (the share of people who see an ad and click it) from 11.07% to 12.66%. Market share, the share of relevant local searches where the ad appeared, edged up again to 19.63%, its sixth consecutive monthly increase. The ads also appeared in the top three positions more often, 64.65% of the time, up from 61.56%.

The **Ford Dealership** campaign continued to lead with 1,377 clicks at a 16.94% click-through rate. Model campaigns posted strong response rates across the board: Explorer 11.67%, Ranger 11.06% and F-150/F-250 9.95%. F-150/F-250 again held the highest market share of any campaign at 23.08%.

Display became more efficient. Display ads, which work like digital billboards on websites and apps, delivered 361,484 impressions and 3,832 clicks. That's about 10% less exposure than August but only 3% fewer clicks, lifting the click-through rate from 0.98% to 1.06%.

Where Shopping Activity Softened

Vehicle detail page views fell 17.2% to 6,901. A vehicle detail page view means someone opened a specific car's listing, the online version of walking up to a vehicle on the lot. New and used views fell by similar amounts (16.9% and 17.7%). With visitor counts essentially flat, the change was in how deeply people shopped once they arrived. Sessions were slightly shorter (2 minutes 22 seconds, versus 2 minutes 30 seconds) and the engagement rate eased from 70.05% to 67.50%. That pattern fits a post-changeover month, when the most motivated buyers have already acted and the next wave is still browsing.

Lead form submissions fell to 45 from 74, and those from ad visitors fell to 7 from 29. That's a real drop and we're not going to soften it. Two things are worth keeping in mind alongside it. First, as noted in previous reports, the site's general contact form was replaced by a chat widget in July. Conversations that happen in chat aren't counted here, so this number captures only part of the inquiry picture. Getting chat volume reported alongside forms remains on our list. Second, direct calls from the ads held up much better, at 80 versus 86. Phone remains the dealership's most direct line from an ad to a conversation.

Where the Traffic Came From

Paid search remained the largest source at 3,871 visitors, up from 3,755. Direct visits contributed 2,638 and organic search 1,073. **Paid video grew to 1,338 visitors**, up from 963, the biggest gain of any channel. Paid social came down to 783 from August's unusually strong 1,081, and display contributed 1,081. Across all sources, visitors completed 8,099 key actions on the site, including vehicle detail views, form fills, phone clicks and visits of five or more pages.

The homepage drew the most visitors (1,940), followed closely by used inventory (1,905) and new inventory (1,575). Among individual models, **Explorer** again drew the most interest with 1,244 visitors, followed by Edge (850), F-150 (616) and Super Duty (397).

Audience and Geography

Knoxville delivered the most ad activity with 211,277 impressions and 3,243 clicks, followed by Alcoa, Oak Ridge, LaFollette and Clinton. As usual, the smaller surrounding communities responded at several times the Knoxville rate: Andersonville clicked at 9.25%, Heiskell 7.60%, Rocky Top 6.89% and Clinton 5.63%. Ad clicks came about 63% from men, and the 55-64 and 65-and-over groups were the two most active age brackets. Desktop computers made up a small share of exposure but clicked at 5.65%, more than three times the mobile rate. That's typical of buyers comparing options carefully before they visit.

Looking Ahead

September kept the advertising engine in good shape: steady reach, sharper search response, a sixth straight gain in market share and more efficient display. The softer number was on-site shopping depth, which tends to dip right after the changeover rush. October and November bring year-end clearance and manufacturer incentives, typically some of the strongest new-vehicle months of the year. The visibility built through the summer leaves the dealership well positioned for that push. We'll be watching vehicle detail views and lead activity closely to confirm the rebound.
